

Tone and pitch

Speakers adjust the tone and pitch of their voice according to what they are saying. For example, someone might sound sad and low-pitched if delivering bad news, but delighted and high-pitched if discussing good news.



Bao Bao, the world's oldest panda, has died at age 34.

This sentence would probably be delivered in an upbeat tone.

In other news, the weather is going to be fantastic this weekend.



Pauses and fillers

When people are thinking about what to say next, or lose their train of thought, they pause. Sometimes people fill the silence with a hesitation device, such as *er* or *huh*, or with a sigh.



So...why did your team play so badly tonight?

An ellipsis stands for a pause when spoken language is written down.

Er...we...have no excuse.

Structure

People often leave out words and use incomplete sentences when they are having spoken conversations. Contractions such as *haven't* and *couldn't* are used more frequently in speech than in written text, because the words are easier to say and help make a conversation flow.



Did you see the game last night?

Awesome, wasn't it?

Yeah.

This isn't a full sentence. The speaker is relying on what was said before for his or her words to make sense.

Reckon we're going to the playoffs now.

The word *I* has been left out, and *we're* has been used instead of *we are*. The informal verb *reckon* is often used in colloquial speech.

GLOSSARY

Accent The way in which a language is pronounced.

Colloquial A word used to describe the language that is used in informal, everyday speech.

Contraction A word that has been shortened by removing letters.

Dialect The informal vocabulary and grammar used by a particular social or geographic group of people.

Pitch The height of a sound.

Tone The feeling or mood projected by a voice—for example, happy, sad, angry, or excited.